were taking Deng Xiaoping's slogan, 'To get rich is glorious', with utter seriousness. Chinese officialdom had become more accessible, and it was now possible to meet Chinese scholars and artists in informal settings. Flea markets had sprung up all across the city, selling counterfeit designer clothes and a whole range of consumer goods. There were weekly antique markets where one could still find some rare and beautiful objects. Five-star hotels had begun to sprout in most cities, and there were many more foreign-brand cars on the road.

But all this gave no indication of the forty-year sprint that would bring China to where it is now – the world's second largest economy after the US, and already a leader in new-age technologies like artificial intelligence, quantum computing and space exploration. India is a retreating image in China's rear-view mirror.

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Despite being two long-standing Asian civilizations, India and China have for centuries been strangers to one another. During the first millennium, the people of the two countries did come into contact with one another. The connections happened through three main channels – the caravan trade through Central Asia, the trade route through Nepal and Tibet and the maritime trade between peninsular India and the east China coast. The spread of Buddhism to China led Buddhist monks and pilgrims like Xuan Zang to make the long journey to India, to obtain authentic Buddhist scriptures and study at the famous universities of Nalanda and Vikramshila. Several Indian monks also travelled to China and served as priests and translators in the country's monasteries. But such encounters were confined to a relatively small group of Indians and Chinese. And while Buddhism did provide a link between the peoples of the two countries, it was mostly one-way traffic. Even during the first millennium, we see little curiosity in India about China and its people. India may have left an impression on China during this period, but we do not see any similar impact of China on India. After 1000 CE , even these limited engagements faded away over the subsequent centuries with the waning of Buddhism in India and in the wake